



MODULE 6

Emotional self-regulation

What do your emotions do to your players, even when you think you're saying nothing?

CORE THEORY

Emotional contagion (Hatfield, Cacioppo & Rapson, 1994) shows that people unconsciously adopt each other's emotions through micro-expressions, tone of voice, and body language. As a coach you are the dominant emotional broadcaster in your group: your tension becomes their tension, your calm becomes their calm. Neuropsychologically this is known as limbic resonance. Your players' amygdalae literally mirror yours. Self-regulation is not a soft skill; it is a performance variable.

Source: Hatfield et al. (1994) · Lewis, Amini & Lannon (2000) · Gross (1998) · Goleman (1995)

"You cannot hide your emotions from people who depend on you. They feel everything."

Daniel Goleman

"The calm coach creates calm athletes. The anxious coach creates anxious athletes. Always."

Steve Peters

SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 What are your three biggest emotional triggers as a coach? (E.g.: losing, lack of effort, mistakes under pressure.)
- 2 How do you physically notice that tension is building during a game? What does that do to your body language?
- 3 When did you last have an emotional reaction you later regretted? What was the trigger?
- 4 How do you prepare yourself for an emotionally demanding game or training? Do you have a routine?
- 5 What do your players do when you are tense? Consciously observe this over the coming weeks.

NOTES

**BOOKS**

- **The Chimp Paradox**
Steve Peters
Why: How the emotional brain works, and how to manage it. Used by Team GB and Chris Hoy. Practical and accessible.
- **Emotional Intelligence**
Daniel Goleman
Why: The scientific foundation of EQ. Read Part 2: why emotions are contagious and how you manage that as a leader.
- **Performing Under Pressure**
Weisinger & Pawliw-Fry
Why: Concrete: how pressure destroys performance and how to reverse that. Includes toolkit for coaches.

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **The Hand Model of the Brain**
Daniel Siegel
[youtube.com/watch?v=gm9CIJ74Oxw](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gm9CIJ74Oxw)
Teach this model to your players too. Understanding how the brain works under pressure is liberating.
- **Managing Your Emotions as a Coach**
Steve Peters (Sport Interview)
[youtube.com/results?search_query=steve+peters+chimp+paradox+coaching](https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=steve+peters+chimp+paradox+coaching)
How Peters works with elite athletes on emotional control in the coach.

**PODCASTS**

- **The High Performance Podcast**
Episode on performance anxiety and pressure regulation in coaches
thehighperformancepodcast.com
- **Finding Mastery**
Episode with Michael Gervais: self-regulation as the foundation of coaching
findingmastery.com

⚡ ACTION THIS WEEK

Develop a 5-minute pre-game routine that emotionally calibrates you. Box breathing (4-4-4-4), body scan, or an intention sentence. Test it for 3 consecutive games.

My personal emotional trigger as a coach I want to work on:
